Plan for single-family houses gains support

By LYNN HORSLEY
The Kansas City Star

A Kansas City Council committee on Wednesday recommended the demolition of seven buildings near one of the city's most notorious corners to make way for new single-family homes.

The Housing and Community Development Committee approved an ordinance to accept a $1.4 million federal grant to tear down seven of the eight buildings in "Lovett Place Apartments," near 27th Street and Benton Boulevard.

"The goal is to make way for single-family houses along Benton Boulevard to complement the older homes there," Councilman Troy Nash said.

The full council will review the measure today.

In June 1996, the intersection of 27th and Benton became a flash point when a drug-related arrest spurred a crowd of more than 100 to throw bottles and rocks at police and to set fire to a car.

Since then, neighborhood activists such as Rosemary Lowe, past president of the Santa Fe Neighborhood Association, have worked to turn around an area known mostly for drug activity and prostitution.

"That's the best blessing we've ever had," Lowe said Wednesday after learning of the committee's acceptance of the federal grant.

The city plans to redevelop the area bounded by 27th Street, Linwood Boulevard, Prospect Avenue and Indiana Avenue.

Seven multifamily buildings will be demolished and another rehabilitated at 2826 Prospect Ave. The city plans to complete a residential and streetscape plan for Benton from 27th to Linwood Boulevard.